

**The Changing Internet Landscape:
How Gemini is Affecting Internet Publishers**

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In 2024, Google unveiled its latest browser feature, "AI Overview." By using Gemini, their generative AI, it scrapes through websites and information related to the user's search to create a summary answer. The premise of the summary is to provide users with answers to their questions quickly and easily, saving time and energy while providing quality information to the user.¹ While that may be beneficial to the user, it raises questions about the impact on the websites that AI uses and the accuracy of the information presented. This paper will examine the impact of Google's use of generative AI on users and publishers, as well as the steps Google took to address these issues.

Following the unveiling of the feature, publishers of content on Google were immediately affected by the decision. When the summary is created, Gemini compiles information about the topic from several related websites. Google does not obtain explicit permission from publishers; instead, inclusion of their content in the AI summary is a requirement for having their website included in Google's search results. The content that publishers post is intellectual property, meaning it is a unique product that has commercial value and can be used to protect the creators' right to be compensated for their work.² When Google takes publishers' content, it uses it to summarize an answer to the user's question. Google argues that the use of the websites' information falls under the Fair Use Exemption, which allows them to use content and short excerpts for teaching, news reporting, and commentary.³ It enables them to take the content and reproduce a summarized version that rephrases and restructures the information. Publishers believe that fair use is not a valid argument for using their articles because it harms the market.

¹ Michael Savage, "AI summaries cause 'devastating' drop in audiences, online news media told," The Guardian, July 24, 2025, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2025/jul/24/ai-summaries-causing-devastating-drop-in-online-news-audiences-study-finds>.

² Jeff Franklin, "L18, L19 Intellectual Property" (presentation, Iowa State University, Ames, IA, November 11, 2025).

³ Jeff Franklin, "L18, L19 Intellectual Property" (presentation, Iowa State University, Ames, IA, November 11, 2025).

When users see answers from Google, they no longer feel the need to click on websites to learn more about the topic. That takes away ad revenue and page engagement from the websites. Companies are losing money and their audience because Google is using their information to create AI overview summaries.

Google claims their use of websites' information falls under the Fair Use Exemption, with the assertion that their AI overview extends beyond just summary. However, the creators of the articles argue that Gemini's AI overview closely paraphrases the information rather than summarizing it. These creators assert that Google is infringing on copyright law, as website information is not even credited in the overview.

Another issue Google's AI Overview faces are its unintentional spread of misinformation. Misinformation is prevalent on the AI Overview, negatively impacting users who utilize the service. There are times when the information provided is entirely inaccurate. It misinterprets information and uses articles from unreliable sources as if they are accurate. When a user searches for a question and sees the answer generated by AI Overview, they may believe the information provided, which may be harmful to them. The AI Overview relies on users to conduct their own research beyond the summary it provides. With 67% of the population in America having less than a bachelor's degree and 39% of the population in America having a high school diploma or less, many US citizens might not have learned how to analyze sources, or possess the critical thinking skills to determine if information is correct.⁴ These skills are typically developed as people progress through school, especially post-secondary education. Not only are many Americans not equipped with the skills to do proper research, but they also trust

⁴ Jeff Franklin, "L21, L22 Cyber Social Impacts" (presentation, Iowa State University, Ames, IA, November 18, 2025).

that the AI is providing accurate information. Therefore, AI Overview, a tool intended to make users' lives easier, instead spreads misinformation.

Following backlash from publishers and users, Google took steps to credit websites for the information they used. They added links following the information, which allows users to navigate to the articles to read further. Additionally, Google refined Gemini to reduce the amount of misinformation provided by AI. However, many believe there is more that could have been done. The citations do little to send users to the original articles. According to The Guardian, a study found that in about 69,000 Google searches, users who used AI Overview clicked on a cited link 1 out of every 100 searches.⁵ Before AI Overview, a user would have gone to those articles every time they searched, but now, websites are seeing drastic drops in their engagement. Websites rely on web traffic and ad revenue for their business and are losing that revenue due to the Google's AI service. Despite Google's efforts to refine Gemini, incorrect information is still frequently provided to users. To prevent the spread of information, Gemini must be further developed.

There are additional programs that Google can implement for publishers and users. Firstly, Google should provide publishers with the ability to opt out of their information being used by AI Overview. Obtaining explicit approval from publishers will help protect creator's rights and intellectual property. Google can also implement a service to share revenue directly with the publishers whose information they are using. Since AI Overview uses direct information from websites and has caused a drastic decrease in website traffic, these publishers should be compensated for their work. This service would provide Google and publishers with a mutually

⁵ Michael Savage, "AI summaries cause 'devastating' drop in audiences, online news media told," The Guardian, July 24, 2025, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2025/jul/24/ai-summaries-causing-devastating-drop-in-online-news-audiences-study-finds>.

beneficial system, where both publishers maintain their profits, and Google retain the companies that provide them with high-quality information.

Google unveiled AI Overview, and it had an immediate impact on consumers and online article publishers. Gemini utilizes articles available on Google's search engine to create summaries that answer users' questions. Their initial implementation of the AI Overview infringed on the publisher's rights by taking their intellectual property and using it without the publisher's express permission. Additionally, the introduction of Google's AI Overview drives users away from the websites of the very publishers from which Gemini is taking the information. It spreads misinformation by misinterpreting or collecting its data from untrustworthy sources. The steps taken by Google to cite users did little to help bring people to their websites, and they have not implemented ways for publishers to opt out of their articles' usage by Gemini. They expanded the program globally and made little progress in addressing the underlying issues. As AI continues to advance, publishers will need to continue fighting for their rights to intellectual property.